

A Response to Dr. Yahya Yasrebi's Theory of Critical Pluralism
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Can all religions be the bearers of the truth? It is my contention that Monotheism as we understand it can in fact be the foundational base for the kerygmatic truth that there is but one God.

How human beings interpret and experience a relationship with God is dependent on the depth and scholarly understanding of their theological knowledge. Theology is based on the study centered on two words; theos, (meaning God) from the original Greek, and ology (a scholarly/academic study of a particular subject), in this case, the study of God and God's relationship to people, their surroundings and the planet upon which all human and biological life depend.

Monotheistic Theology from an academic context focuses on the written word as contained in the Holy Books of all three monotheistic religions (Judaism, Christianity and Islam.) If theology is the academic discipline and study of God, then it must be exposed and studied through its connectivity with history and when each monotheistic theology's oral tradition was initially canonized; (when theological texts for a particular

monotheistic faith were put into written form as being authoritative.) Also the “science” of the theological study of the three monotheistic faiths must be willing to balance and articulate how post modernistic thinking, secularism and globalization impact emerging new insights and interpretations of traditional, theological canonized texts. Not to engage in such due diligence and study has generated a level of theological illiteracy that gives rise to a theological rigidity, fundamentalism and protectionism that supports the belief that my religion is the only one that is true. And because of that “my religion” has the right and authority to demean and condemn that of another as unauthoritative and ultimately incorrect.

The One God of Abrahamic religions does not activate, empower or engage in the horror of the civil wars or the demeaning of one’s theological faith over another. A careful and open study of monotheistic theologies condemns sectarian violence and indiscriminant terrorism against innocents, women and children. Those who engage in such sectarian acts of violence and death have lost the most fundamental principles of Judaism, Christianity and Islam. They have become the 21st century secular oppressors responsible for creating hundreds of thousands of homeless refugees. They have become responsible for the slaughter of millions over the centuries because of religious wars and asymmetrical violence. They are not people of The Book, but rather people who are bigots and terrorists fed by ignorance and theological

illiteracy. They are people who have lost their humanity by believing in a specter, a ghost, a fantasy they have created as their own personal image of God. Theirs is a God created out of darkness, scriptural illiteracy and fantasy. Theirs is a false God empowering them to engage in cruelty, fanaticism and dominance that feeds their intolerance. The kerygmatic teaching of all monotheistic faiths however affirm mercy, love, compassion, forgiveness and the knowledge that all of creation is good and that believers have the responsibility of being stewards of all that God has created.

Ayatollah Seyyed Mostafa Mohaghegh Damad, a friend and highly respected Iranian Shi'a theologian, jurist and philosopher wrote; "In today's world, due to the behavior of certain believers, religion has become coupled with violence. Sadly, the religions that used to be accounted as the messengers of peace, friendship, morality and tranquility, have become, in many parts of the world, as the cause for bloody and violent feuds. Therefore, I believe that the arch duty of religious leaders sic (scholars) today is to wipe out these emerging ugly and hideous appearances of the religions, to try clarifying and showing the real beauties and righteous facets of all holy faiths, and to return this divinely-given gift its real status. We the followers of the Abrahamic religions believe in a God who is the true meaning of generosity, love, affection, friendship, and justice. God apparently in all divine books is referred to as; affectionate, full of kindness, peace, all compassionate, all beneficent, all conserver, all excusing, all

forgiving, all wise and all laudable. All these qualities have been enumerated for God. But the meaning of piety for people worshipping God according to these principles and qualities will never lead to violence”.

During the years of my journey in interreligious dialogue, I have had the opportunity to travel throughout the world to spend time with leading Jewish, Christian and Muslim scholars and clerics. For me, my respect and openness to their articulation of their belief in God’s presence that encompasses their life is essential. At the same time, I have always been respected by the believers of other monotheistic faiths for my belief in God’s presence that encompasses my life.

All people of The Book worship by faith in the same God! Yet all monotheists have a significant vehicle that helps them pass from the secular world to the embrace and sacredness of the one living God. For Jews, the vehicles for the journey are Moses and the Prophets. For Christian’s it is Jesus. And for Muslims it is Muhammad. All of them lead us to the one God. Which of these vehicles is greater than the other? None of them! Each in their own way carry the believer on the unique path of knowing God through their Holy Books and on-going 21st century theological scholarship that continues to enlighten and grow their faith. “Behold I make all things new.”

In closing I recall a dialogue I had with the late Huston Smith at The Chautauqua Institution in New York. Before his death, Huston was considered to be a significant American theologian

and author and one of the foremost interpreters of world religions. My point is our dialogue was about religion in general and theology in specifics that had been unable to develop a new language to engage in discussion with science on most matters pertaining to the relationship between science and religion. As a 21st century reality, Science is constantly changing and morphing with new and challenging discoveries revealed every day regarding the nature of our universe. Theology has become the antithesis of science and has become entrenched, static and defensive. This defensiveness is based to a great extent on the fact that organized religion continues to diminish in numbers especially within Christian denominations. Science and technology are changing at such a speed that it is hard for theology to keep up with it and relate it to the eternal realities that define the science of understanding and knowledge of God.

Dr. Francis S. Collins (an atheist and scientist) who heads the Human Genome Project and a leader in the study of DNA and its coding of life said recently that over the years he has begun to be a believer in God and affirms that faith and science can and must co-exist. And that the formation of the earth as a planet may possibly be a Godly experiment.

Stephan Hawking, world renowned Physicist commented; “the odds against a universe like ours emerging out of something like the Big Bang theory are enormous. I think there are clearly religious implications”. He also wrote in his book A Brief History

of Time; "It would be very difficult to explain why the universe should have begun in just this way, except as an act of God who intended to create beings like us."

Blessings to you Dr.Yasrebi. I do miss my visits to Iran and especially in conjunction with friends and colleagues at Tehran's CID and old friends I worked with from Iran who used to be able to travel to the US and Washington National Cathedral.